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"WE ENJOY WORKING here and it's largely no different from working in Delhi or Mumbai. But we wish the social life were a little better. There's not much to do after work," say Niharika and Seema (names changed on request) who are walking down for lunch at their office cafeteria when this writer bumps into them.

32 | The 20-somethings have been working with a foreign bank at GIFT City in Gujarat, for the past one and a half years. "There are a lot of young people like us working here who live in Ahmedabad or Gandhinagar," they say, and before rushing off for lunch, point towards the hectic construction activity taking place all around.

If there's one phrase that can describe GIFT City—spread across 1,000 acres of land and just a 20-minute drive from Ahmedabad's Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel International Airport—right now, it is furious activity. Work is on at a frenzied pace—residential apartments, a school and even a hospital are being built around offices in steel and glass towers that are humming with people, amid vast expanses of vacant land. Announced in June 2007, Gujarat International Finance Tec-City or GIFT City, one of India's long-standing ambitions

to house an international financial services centre (IFSC) on the lines of the ones in Singapore and Dubai, is ready for take-off.

Considered a pet project of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, it has got a boost from the central government in recent years. Several companies in the financial services space have set up shop in GIFT City, which currently has an estimated 400 offices, where 26,000 people work.

A key reason for this progress has been the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA), set up in April 2020 under the International Financial Services Centres Authority Act, 2019. Over the past few years, it has kept a sharp focus on putting in place comprehensive regulations to get the place going and continues to be in discussions with ministries to make the jurisdiction more business- and investor friendly.

"The establishment of the GIFT IFSCA, integrating Indian financial markets with global financial markets, is part of our larger reforms," Prime Minister Modi had said at the investor conference Infinity Forum in December, noting that the vision for GIFT City has been crafted as a dynamic ecosystem that will redefine the landscape of international finance. "It will set new benchmarks for innovation, efficiency, and global collaboration. The establishment of the IFSCA as a unified regulator in 2020 is a crucial landmark in this journey," he had underlined.

IFSCA Chairperson K. Rajaraman notes that there is a set of foreign investors who are still not directly investing in India. "We would want them to come into a jurisdiction (GIFT City) where they feel at ease in terms of ease of doing business, the quality of the regulations, the clarity of the regulations, tax certainty and so on," he tells *Business Today*, adding that this has started happening now.

The buzz around GIFT City was evident at the recent Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2024. The PM, in his inaugural address, announced that the UAE's sovereign wealth fund will soon launch operations there. As part of the summit, he also took part in the

WITH A BOW ON TOP



2007

First proposed by then Gujarat CM Narendra Modi as an international financial centre (IFC)



2015

The Government of India notifies India's first IFSC